

Playbooks Report

Issue

May 2026

Created by

Curiosity Centre

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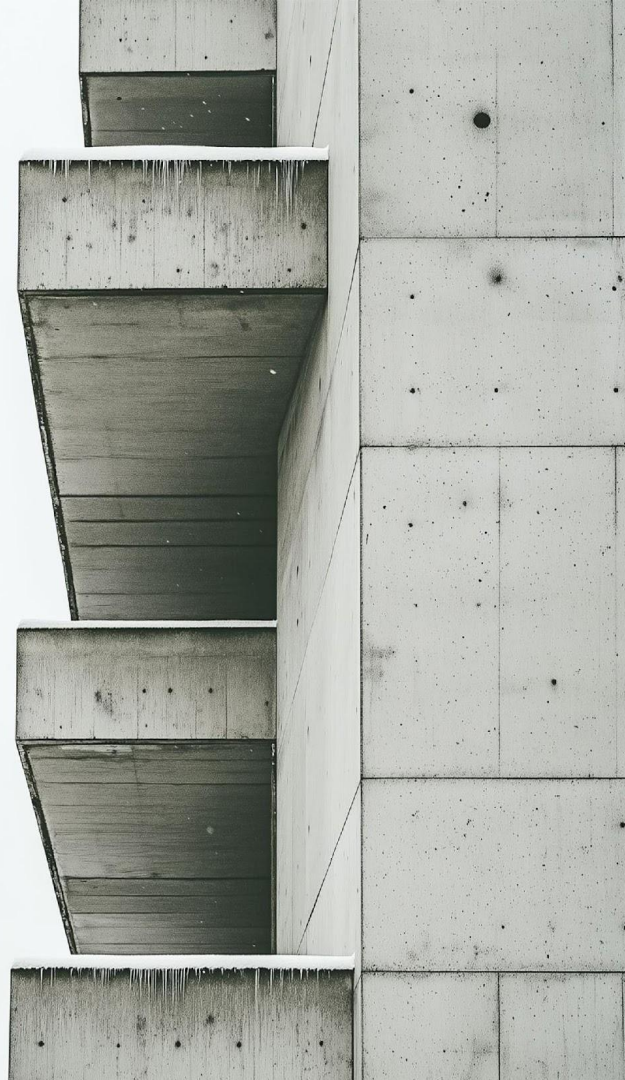
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Why This Report Exists



Vidit Agarwal

Founder & CEO, Curiosity Centre
Host, The High Flyers Podcast
Investor, FB10x

Over the past six years of building Curiosity Centre, hosting hundreds of conversations on The High Flyers Podcast, and getting a front row seat to how high-growth companies really operate, one thing has become very clear:

We spend a lot of time celebrating startup theatre – Funding rounds, valuations, big headlines.

But far less time understanding what actually happened underneath those outcomes.

That gap is exactly why this report exists, and why my team and I continue to pour so much into bringing each new edition to life.

In this edition, a few things kept surprising me: several of the biggest growth unlocks came from decisions that looked counterintuitive at first, the strongest teams resisted the instinct to simply hire when something broke, and much of the real momentum was driven by internal mechanics the outside world rarely sees.

In other words, most of the breakthroughs were happening internally, long before they ever showed up as public milestones.

Inside these pages, we unpack the real operating playbooks behind Hapana, Rosterfy, AutoGrab, Mutinex, Airwallex and Everlab — six very different scale-ups, each with practical lessons on growth, systems, customer retention, product decisions and commercial execution.

This report is for founders, operators and investors who are less interested in startup theatre and more interested in the real mechanics behind strong companies.

My hope is that somewhere in these pages, you find at least one specific idea worth taking back into your own company.

Thank you to the village of people for working tirelessly behind the scenes to gather this information.

The Patterns That Kept Repeating

01

Fix the operating logic before adding people

The strongest teams did not respond to pressure by immediately hiring. They first built clearer workflows, scoring systems, ownership structures and automation layers.

02

Counterintuitive decisions created the biggest growth unlocks

Several of the major inflection points came from doing the opposite of what conventional startup wisdom suggests: centralising before expanding, going global before local teams, or staying manual longer.

03

Incentives changed behaviour faster than culture did

The companies that moved quickest did not just ask teams to perform better.

They changed what people were measured, rewarded and held accountable for.

04

Move closer to where the transaction actually happens

Data, education and dashboards created interest, but the strongest monetisation came when companies inserted themselves directly into the customer's moment of action.

05

Turn industry mess into proprietary infrastructure

The best moats were built by absorbing complexity others avoided: fragmented healthcare workflows, noisy fitness churn signals, enterprise marketing ambiguity and systemising them internally.

Hapana

Founded in 2014, Hapana provides fitness management software for gyms, boutique studios, and fitness franchises worldwide. The platform helps ambitious fitness businesses manage operations, engage members, and scale across multiple locations.

Team size: 120 employees

Locations: Headquartered in Sydney, with employees across US, Singapore, India and UK

Jarron Aizen
Founder / CEO
Hapana



Adam Faludi
Head of Customer Success
Hapana



Michael Chetner
Chief Revenue Officer
Hapana



Retention as an operating system

The reactive trap

Most CS teams are built to react. They find out a customer is at risk when the customer tells them i.e. in a support ticket, a delayed renewal, or a cancellation notice.

By then, the relationship is already damaged and the outcome is largely determined.

Hapana solution

Hapana built a system that predicts churn 30–60 days before it happens — without doubling headcount.

Total brands 298

Locations 1,464

ANZ revenue 70%

GRR target >94%

How Hapana does it differently

💖 Daily health scores, not human instinct

Every account has a daily health score. When it drops, the system acts — not the CSM.

One number drives all segmentation

All segmentation decisions trace back to \$2M USD revenue per CSM.

🚫 Rejected every generic CS platform

They rejected Gainsight, ChurnZero, and Vitality. Fitness-specific data doesn't fit generic SaaS models.

🔗 ICP discipline is a retention strategy

Saying no to single-location customers is a retention strategy — and the data backs it.

💖 AI fixed the mid-market QBR gap

Mid-market accounts were being skipped for QBRs. AI cut prep time by 80% and fixed the gap.

Contrarian take

Don't hire into your target market — centralise first.

While competitors rushed to put Customer Success teams on the ground in the US, Hapana kept the function in Australia.

The logic: exporting a broken playbook just scales the problem. Get the model right. Then expand it.

A customer's health score dropped from 82 to 54 in two weeks following a payment gateway migration. An automated alert fired.

Within 48 hours, the CSM and support lead ran a joint triage call — before the customer raised a complaint. The account recovered to 78 within 30 days.

They never churned.

Hapana's Customer Retention in Practise

Define your revenue-per-CSM target first. Every segmentation, hiring, and tooling decision flows from this number.

Map the signals that predict churn. Generic health scores won't do it. Weight the 5–7 signals that actually matter in your industry.

Automate volume. Reserve humans for judgment. The goal isn't fewer CSMs, it's CSMs who only touch the moments that need a human.

>94%

Gross revenue retention

125%

Net revenue retention

<5%

Logo churn

\$2M

Revenue per CSM



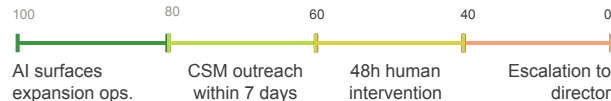
Health score (0-100)

A score created from 7 signals that predict churn

25%	Product usage	Analytics
20%	Payment status	Stripe / Maxio
15%	Support volume	Hubspot
10%	Support sentiment	AI analysis
10%	NPS/CSAT	Survey
10%	Onboarding completion	Internal
10%	Engagement	Hubspot + product



Actions based on health score



04

Rosterfy

Rosterfy is the world's leading volunteer management platform, used by charities, hospitals, events, cities and sporting federations to simplify and streamline the entire volunteer journey from start to finish. Powered by advanced automation, AI, and configurable workflows, it reduces administrative burden, ensures compliance, and delivers a seamless, engaging experience for both administrators and volunteers.

Team size: 75 employees

Locations: Melbourne, Sydney, London, Denver, New York, Dubai

Shannan Gove
Co-Founder / Head of Sales
Rosterfy



Bennett Merriman
Co-Founder, CEO
Rosterfy



The "Reverse Sequence" Global Strategy

Rosterfy flipped the traditional playbook: going global first with minimal team, then building operational capacity driven by revenue, not forecasts.

01 Sign, Then Hire

Founder (Shannan) signed major UK customers from Melbourne with under 5 staff. Revenue justifies the hire, not just a business plan.

02 First Customer as Co-Developer

Tough Mudder funded 40% of the product build as a partner. Don't just sell, find partners to shape your roadmap.

03 The "Hero Number"

A one-pager showing \$1M saved metric closed the NFL as an early customer. One ROI metric can replace a lengthy sales process.

Operational pressure forced ruthless focus and hustle on every opportunity that mattered.



Rosterfy's Leapfrog Strategy in Practise

Investor rejection forced the pivot from Sports Organisations to Not-For-Profits. It worked, and has grown to over 76% of revenue (up from 5% in 2019).

	2015	2019	2025
How the team scaled	Zero local presence. Melbourne HQ supporting UK/US logos remotely.	First hires in US/UK only after revenue was confirmed.	In 4 markets. Dominating global markets with senior directors in-region.
Team size	5	20	75
NFP Customers as % of Total revenue	0%	5%	76%

Market and vertical adaptations

USA

Direct culture, open to cold outreach. Localise spelling, domain, and case.

UK / AU

Relationship-first. Warm intros consistently outperform cold.

NFP vs sports

Completely different sale. Procurement panels, 3–6m cycles, audit trails required. Relationship selling from sports did not transfer.



The insight most people miss

Re-run your total addressable market (TAM) before you expand verticals.

New verticals look adjacent. They rarely are.

Map the full GTM from scratch: the buyer, sales cycle, procurement, and pricing.



Market Signals We're Seeing Across High-Growth Companies

1. Rapid Agent Adoption

Build, scale, and govern autonomous agents that take action with the Agent Development Kit (ADK) and Agent Runtime.

2. Use AI across your stack

From AI Hypercomputer infrastructure to Gemini 3.1 models, we handle the engineering so you can focus on performance and efficiency.

3. Open by Design

Avoid vendor lock-in. Our strategy supports open models and third-party tools, giving you the flexibility.

4. Enterprise-Ready Security

Build trust from day one. Our Agentic Defense capabilities, including zero-trust security and sovereignty controls, ensure your AI solutions are secure, stable, and ready for enterprise.

5. Data quality is now the limiting factor in AI ROI

Turn data into action. The Agentic Data Cloud grounds AI in "enterprise truth" using the Knowledge Catalog, while BigQuery Fluid Scaling reduces costs by up to 34% for unpredictable workloads.

5 AI trends shaping 2026

1 Agents for every employee

Empowering individuals to achieve peak productivity



2 Agents for every workflow

Running your business with grounded agentic systems



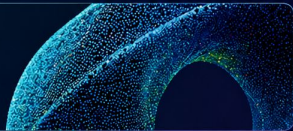
3 Agents for your customers

Delighting customers with concierge-like experiences



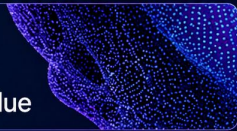
4 Agents for security

Advancing security from alerts to action



5 Agents for scale

Upskilling talent will be the ultimate driver of business value



05

AutoGrab

AutoGrab is the automotive industry's leading data and AI platform, used by dealers, dealer groups, OEMs, insurers, and financial institutions across Australia, the UK, and Southeast Asia to source, value, and transact vehicles with confidence. Powered by live market intelligence, advanced AI, and deep integrations across the automotive ecosystem, it eliminates guesswork, accelerates decisions, and drives measurable outcomes across the entire vehicle lifecycle — from acquisition through to sale.

Team size: ~100 employees

Locations: Melbourne, Sydney, Brisbane, London, Kuala Lumpur

Steven Bearzatto
Chief Technology Officer
AutoGrab



Stewart Bird
Chief Innovation Officer
AutoGrab



Data was never the product. The transaction was.

The insight that changed everything — and what CBA showed us before we'd named it.

ACT 01 — THE DATA BET

We built the data layer.

Pricing history. Insurance data. Vehicle intelligence at scale. We believed the dataset was the product — irreplaceable, proprietary, the thing customers were paying for.

"We thought the data was the product. We were right about the data. Wrong about the product."

ACT 02 — THE PIVOT

We discovered the network.

1,000+ dealers. 90%+ of insurers. Operating on a shared network we'd built without naming it.

"We didn't build the network intentionally. We looked up one day and realised we already had."

ACT 03 — TRANSACTION INFRASTRUCTURE

Data + network = a transaction rail.

AI synthesises data, matches parties, and curates transaction logic. Customers pay for deals closed — not dashboards.

"Customers don't pay for insight. They pay for what happens after the insight."

THE TURNING POINT — COMMONWEALTH BANK OF AUSTRALIA

Why CBA came to us

CBA could source data elsewhere. What they couldn't replicate was the live network of 1,000+ dealers and 90%+ of insurers on a single platform. They came for the infrastructure, not the feed.

"They saw what we'd built before we'd named it."

The data made the network intelligent. But the network was the asset.

What it became

Axel AI by AutoGrab — connecting customers with vehicles in-marketplace at the moment of decision.

OUTCOME

Multi-agent infrastructure handling industry-wide transaction logic and match marketing.

Building the transaction network: AutoGrab's blueprint

How AutoGrab evolved from a data company to a mission-critical transaction hub, and how to replicate their success.

The stack

Data Beachhead

Irreplaceable dataset built over years — pricing, history.

SaaS Workflows

Embedded intelligence into daily dealer and insurer decisions.

Network Density

1,000+ dealers. 90%+ of insurers. Connective tissue at scale.

Transaction Hub

Positioned at the center of every deal. All roads lead here.

AI Distribution

Intelligence embedded where users are.

Org design



Chief Innovation Officer (CIO)

New role. Owns AI + the network layer. Operates at the frontier, responsible for what the business becomes.



Chief Product Officer (CPO)

SaaS and product engine. Keeps the core running while the frontier expands.



Chief Technology Officer (CTO)

Deliberately blurred lines between product and engineering allowing for speed over structure. This ensures the company is AI first.

The “Triad” Principle

CIO, CPO, and CTO operate as a single decision layer — every frontier bet runs through the same network and transaction-first lens as the product itself.

Autograb's execution logic

Your data is the foundation, not the moat

Data is a means to an end and insights without action aren't worth much. Focus on the transaction the data enables.

Watch for the network hiding in your product

Look at networks you're already embedded in. Find the connections you haven't monetised yet.

Define the Transaction First

Does this facilitate a transaction? If not, cut it or reposition it. No exceptions.

AI without a closing transaction is noise

Before building any AI feature, define the transaction it's meant to close. Intelligence without a destination is noise.

06

Mutinex

Mutinex is an AI-powered growth as a service platform built to solve one of the biggest problems in marketing: knowing what's actually working. Used by enterprise brands, agencies, and media companies worldwide, it helps marketers measure ROI, optimise budgets, and make faster, more confident growth decisions.

Team size: 74 employees

Locations: Melbourne, Sydney, New York.

Nicky Barton
Head of Marketing Science
Mutinex



William Marks
Head of Data Solutions
Mutinex



Shane Treeves
Chief Operating Officer
Mutinex



From Gut Feel to Real Outcomes: The Customer Value Index (CVI)

How Mutinex turned customer outcomes into a measurable system that aligns team compensation with value creation.

INFLECTION POINTS

Measurement

Gut feel → Structure.

Answering "is this account at risk?" required checking five separate dashboards. Nobody did it. The CVI collapsed five separate dashboards into one number people actually use.

Utility

Project → Decision Tool.

Only once people started using it to justify decisions — "they're green in 5 of 8, here's where to focus" build trust. Utility preceded adoption.

It started as two slides

"Make numbers bigger, make numbers smaller." Board of Directors buy-in achieved with two slides and a spreadsheet before engineering spend.

Automation was the credibility layer

While manual, people said "I haven't updated it yet, so that's not right." Auto-refresh every morning at 8AM killed the doubt. The data didn't change, the trust did.

Targets set at aspirational great

They launched at 43%. Mutinex set the bar at what excellent looks like years from now — not current average.

The real unlock was changing incentives

Marketing Science Partners previously had KPI's on Monthly Active Users (MAUs) only — one metric and the most gameable. You can spike MAUs by running a training session. You can't spike all eight CVI metrics at once.

Changing team bonus structure from MAUs alone to the composite index was the moment the whole company started pulling in the same direction on customer outcomes.

CONTRARIAN INSIGHT

Most companies build health scores to manage risk. Mutinex built theirs to change what every team is paid to do.

How Mutinex turned customer value into a viral revenue engine

The 6-step blueprint for aligning internal incentives with absolute customer excellence.

01

Define good

Set at long-run excellence, not current average. +50%. Choose metrics that span the full surface area of customer value.

02

Build simple

Spreadsheet first. Present the principle to the board. Get alignment before investing a single dollar in infrastructure.

03

Automate

Daily 8AM refresh via Amplitude + Hex + Salesforce. Without automation the score is always "wrong" and trust never builds.

★ Critical

04

Make ambient

Big screen in the office. Passive awareness creates social pressure. Not buried in a BI tool nobody opens.

05

Tie to compensation

Marketing Science team must have 80% of customers at 80%+ CVI for their bonus. This is the step that changes everything.

★ Critical

06

Launch promise

Flagship event, stage announcement — not an account review email. Treat it like a product launch.

07

Everlab

Everlab is Australia's leading preventive health service combining cutting-edge diagnostics, world-class clinicians, and personalised medical interventions to detect, prevent, and reverse the risk of disease, years before symptoms show. Used by individuals and corporates, it replaces reactive medicine with a proactive, data-driven alternative that turns health insights into action across the full member journey, from baseline assessment through to ongoing monitoring and clinical intervention.

Team size: ~100 employees

Locations: Sydney, Melbourne, and soon in New Zealand and the UK

Sam Kothari
Co-Founder / COO
Everlab



Anshul Jain
Co-Founder / CTPO
Everlab



How Everlab turned operational chaos into infrastructure — and made it their moat

Every other health startup avoids operational complexity. Everlab absorbed it. That decision — and the infrastructure it forced them to build — is now their primary competitive advantage. Proprietary longitudinal data cannot be bought or replicated quickly, even with significant capital.

Investors told Everlab to simplify — pick one diagnostic. Their counter: the insight only exists when the full picture is complete. Partial data gives partial answers. The complexity they chose to own is exactly what makes the insight possible.

The full picture

A single diagnostic delivers no real insight. Everlab stitches together pathology, imaging, genetics, wearables, and lifestyle data — the healthcare insight only exists when all inputs are present.

Complexity as moat

Anyone can build a nice front-end. Years of real member journeys cannot be bought or replicated quickly — even with significant capital.

Manual before machine

Automate only once a process has run identically ten times without breaking. Automating a broken process gives you broken automation at scale — they stayed manual longer, intentionally.

Speed through hierarchy

One CEO with veto power. Consensus abandoned in the first six months after it created paralysis. A wrong decision in two weeks beats a right decision in three months.

The Execution System: From Manual to Infrastructure

Five principles that turned operational complexity into durable competitive advantage.

01

Start with observation

The Founder sat in with doctors during consultations, watched where their eyes moved, tracked every broken handoff. He did the receptionist's job himself for months.

03

Fix only what you control

They don't own pathology centres or train third-party staff. Every fix had to work without changing the provider's behaviour. The constraint forced more creative solutions.

05 Build products that are seamless to adopt.

Doctors who skipped consult notes got an AI copilot telling them exactly what to click next. Forced workflow paths meant the path of least resistance is designed to be the right one.

02

Measure error rates obsessively

Tracked error rate per member, per provider, per step. A 1% swing across thousands of members is hundreds of broken experiences. Every error got a root cause and a candidate fix.

04

Automate only stable processes

Ask: has this run identically ten times without breaking? If yes, systematise. If still iterating, automation locks in the wrong version. Build for the \$1B business, not just today's.

FEEDBACK LOOP · READ BY ALL 4 FOUNDERS DAILY

1 Member interaction

Real-time experience tracked across every touchpoint in the member journey.

2 Company-wide Slack channel

All feedback routed instantly — founders read every entry, daily.

3 Bot surfaces weekly themes

Patterns identified and prioritised automatically from raw feedback volume.

4 Operations fix now. Engineering fixes root cause.

Two-speed response: immediate triage and structural repair run in parallel.

08

Airwallex

Airwallex is an AI-native global financial operating system for modern businesses, used by fast-growing startups, enterprises, and platforms to manage accounts, payments, spend, cards, and embedded finance in one place. Built on proprietary infrastructure, real-time data, and advanced automation, it replaces fragmented banking and finance tools with a single, scalable platform—reducing costs and manual work, strengthening compliance, and delivering a seamless experience for finance teams and their customers.

Team size: 2,200+ employees

Locations: 26 locations worldwide

Annual Recurring Revenue (ARR): US\$1.2B (Dec 2025)

Taylor Fox-Smith

Startups Lead, Australia & NZ
Airwallex



Ryan Thoo

Startups Marketing Lead, Global
Airwallex



Sell Nothing First: The Trust Led Growth Engine

This is how Airwallex wired its commercial engine to own the startup market.

What most companies get wrong

Most startup programs live inside marketing with no commercial mandate. They measure events run, not revenue unlocked. Airwallex made trust a commercial input — and built the incentive architecture to prove it.

Community was placed inside the commercial function — not marketing

The structural placement meant community had to balance brand tracking with accounting for leads generated, partner referrals and product usage.

The first 12 months had no quantitative KPIs. This was a deliberate choice.

Leadership gave budget and trust. Success, alongside tracking commercial measure, was predominantly reported through inbound interest.

The program launched in 3 verticals with 3 partners. Not broad — surgical.

Seed stage only. Find specific communities that are specialists. One partner per vertical. One target stage. Total focus.

The sales team KPI for startup accounts was changed to: account opened.

Removing gross profit as the success metric removed the structural reason salespeople avoided early-stage founders. This single change unlocked internal buy-in.

And then win by being mythological. The Airwallex way.

The model

01

Map — Identify 3 priority verticals. One partner per vertical. Seed stage only. No generalist programs.

02

Infiltrate — Show up with value first. Education, events, connections. No pitch. Build personal brand before any commercial conversations.

03

Incentivise — Change the internal KPI. Sales team measured on account opened, not gross profit. This removes the structural reason to ignore early stage.

04

Expand — Once trust is established in market, replicate the model. Global lead centralised. Regional lead localised.

The Org

🌐 **Global Lead (Ryan Thoo, Singapore)** — Centralised strategy, product, and partner decisions. Owns the global framework.

🏠 **Regional Lead (Taylor Fox-Smith, Sydney)** — Localised execution. Community, events, and startup relationships in-market.

What they measure

01

Leads generated per partner

02

Transacting customers (not just

03

Active partners in market

04

Portfolio penetration %

Replication steps

01 Map your segments — identify 3 verticals where trust can be built fast.

02 Find specialist partners — one per vertical, not aggregators.

03 Run community events — no sales agenda, pure value delivery.

04 Redesign incentives — change what your sales team is measured on.

05 Measure penetration — track % of portfolio transacting, not just accounts opened.



The lesson — One-off grants create noise without sustained relationships. Structural commitment through budget, headcount and incentive alignment is what separates growth

The real work of building strong companies rarely makes the headline.

We hope these pages helped make more of it visible.

CURIOSITY CENTRE

Featuring contributions from

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 **Airwallex**

 **AutoGrab**

 **hapana**

 **rosterfy**

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See you in the next edition.

Through multiple editions each year, Curiosity Centre continues to unpack the systems, decisions and lessons behind high-growth companies across the four markets we operate in.

We hope somewhere in these pages, you found at least one practical idea worth taking back into your own company.

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